

off debt, we emphatically recommend to make paying off any high-interest debt your first priority. That's because working on any other financial goal with high-interest debt is always two steps forward, three steps back. High-interest debt makes everything harder to achieve. What constitutes "high-interest" changes depending on who you ask, but it will typically always include credit cards, personal loans, and private student loans.

Investing

This aspect of finances has been an area I (Jill) have felt the least confident about. And my lack of knowledge and pursuit of other money goals led me to ignore this category of financial literacy. I assumed investing wasn't for me because I was too broke, or too focused on debt-payoff, or too incapable of understanding the intricacies of making my money grow. I had all the excuses. Until I let myself believe that I could have wealth.

It still feels odd saying it. I can have wealth. But for me, I know if I pursue this it means wealth in all aspects of my life. I can experience fullness relationally, emotionally, and financially. And my definition of wealth may be far different from someone else's.

Once we give ourselves permission to pursue growing our money, we start to realize what that could mean for us, our family, and our community. And at that point, it becomes a social responsibility.

This may not come as a surprise, but women are the best investors out there. In an analysis of more than five million Fidelity customers⁵ over the last ten years, it was found that on average, women not only saw positive returns on their investments but also outperformed their male counterparts. The bummer about it is that many women don't invest, even if they have the money. That same study reported 31 percent of women had \$50K or more sitting in a savings account. Others had even higher amounts they were stashing away, not allowing that money to grow.

Money is power, and we believe power should be in the hands of good, well-intentioned, thoughtful people. Not because good can't be done without money, but it certainly doesn't hurt! It is true that what we do with little we will do with a lot. But what if we can do a lot with our little now, and a lot with our a lot later?